

Roadmap to an Impressive Teaching Voice

A step-by-step guide for recording technical lectures on Udemy

Goal: a voice that is **clear, warm, and easy to follow**. For technical lectures, clarity beats fancy delivery, and students stay longer with a voice that feels like a friendly expert.

Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1-2)

1. Fix your breathing

Most weak voices come from shallow chest breathing.

- Practice diaphragmatic breathing: hand on belly, inhale through the nose for 4 counts (belly expands), exhale on "sss" for 8-10 counts.
- Do this for 5 minutes daily.

2. Fix your posture

Record standing or sitting upright, with feet flat, shoulders relaxed, and screen at eye level. A slouched posture compresses your voice.

3. Do a daily vocal warm-up (5-10 min)

- Lip trills and humming, sliding up and down your range
- Tongue twisters, starting slow: "red leather, yellow leather" and "unique New York"
- Drink room-temperature water. Avoid very cold drinks, heavy dairy, and excess caffeine before recording.

Phase 2: Core Speech Skills (Weeks 3-4)

4. Articulation

- Finish your word endings (t, d, k, s). Listeners lose technical terms when endings are swallowed.
- Read aloud with a pen held lightly between your teeth for 2 minutes, then repeat without it.
- Pronounce technical terms correctly. Check unfamiliar ones on Forvo or Google's audio pronunciation.

5. Pace

- Aim for about **130-150 words per minute**. Udemy learners often watch at 1.25x-1.5x speed, so speaking too fast becomes unintelligible.
- Slow down for definitions, code, and key concepts. Speed up slightly for transitions.

6. Strategic pauses

- Pause for 1 second after key points and 2 seconds before a new section.
- Pauses give learners time to think and remove the need for "um" and "uh."

7. Pitch and intonation

- Avoid monotone. Mark your script with (rise) for questions and (fall) for statements and conclusions.
- Emphasize one or two important words per sentence.
- Finish sentences with a downward tone. A constantly rising tone sounds unsure.

8. Stress and rhythm (especially for Indian English speakers)

- You don't need to remove your accent. A clear, consistent accent is fine.
- Focus on word stress (**data**, **algorithm**, **algorithmic**) and on stressing content words over filler words.

Phase 3: Lecture Delivery (Weeks 5-6)

9. Write a semi-script

Don't read word for word and don't wing it.

- Write short, conversational sentences (under 20 words).
- Use bullet points for structure and full sentences only for key explanations and intros.
- Read the script aloud once before recording. If you stumble, rewrite the sentence.

10. Use a consistent lecture structure

- **Hook:** what the learner will achieve (15 seconds)
- **Concept** explanation
- **Demo** or example
- **One-line recap**

11. Smile while speaking

It changes tone audibly and makes you sound warmer.

12. Speak to one person

Imagine a single student sitting across from you. Say "you" and "we," not "students" or "everyone."

Phase 4: Recording Setup

13. Equipment (budget-friendly)

- Microphone: a USB condenser or dynamic mic such as the Audio-Technica ATR2100x-USB, Samson Q2U, or FIFINE K669. Even a good lavalier mic beats a laptop mic.
- Pop filter, plus a mic stand or boom arm
- Closed headphones for monitoring

14. Acoustics

Room echo ruins good voices.

- Record in a small room with soft furnishings (curtains, bed, sofa, wardrobe of clothes).
- Avoid empty rooms and bare walls. Stay away from fans and AC noise, and record outside peak traffic hours.
- Keep the mic 4-6 inches from your mouth, slightly off-axis.

15. Software

- Use Audacity (free), Reaper, or Adobe Audition. Udemy's audio requirements include:
- Clear audio with no echo or background noise
- Consistent volume (around -3 dB to -5 dB peaks)
- Mono or stereo, MP3 at 192 kbps or higher

Phase 5: Review and Improve (Ongoing)

16. Record and listen critically

- Am I too fast or monotone?
- Are there filler words, breath noises, or mouth clicks?
- Is my energy consistent from start to end?

17. Compare against models

Study instructors whose delivery you admire, such as Andrew Ng, Andrei Neagoie, and Jose Portilla. Notice their pauses and energy, and use those as reference points, not something to copy exactly.

18. Get feedback

Share a 2-minute sample with 2-3 friends or peers and ask, "Where did you lose attention?"

19. Edit lightly

Remove long pauses, loud breaths, and mistakes. Don't over-edit, because a natural voice feels human.

Daily Practice Routine (20-30 min)

Time	Activity
5 min	Breathing and vocal warm-up
5 min	Tongue twisters and articulation
10 min	Read a technical article aloud with expression
5-10 min	Record a 1-minute explanation of a concept, then playback

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Reading a script in a flat "reading voice"
- Speaking too fast when nervous
- Recording tired or dehydrated
- Recording an entire lecture in one take (record in short segments of 3-5 minutes and re-record mistakes)
- Chasing perfection instead of finishing the course

First Steps This Week

- 1 Start the daily 5-minute breathing and warm-up routine.
- 2 Record a 2-minute explanation of any technical topic on your phone.
- 3 Listen back and note two things to improve.